

Never Build Alone

A Story of Fathers, Sons, and the American Dream

Public Voice Packet

I am starting with the work I already have - the writing that has been published or shared publicly over the years. I want you to read this first as a way of getting a feel for my public voice: how I think, what I return to, how I move between personal experience and larger questions, and how the economic and civic work has developed.

Once you have digested this material, I will share the unpublished and more private writing. That material includes the deeper family history, the vignettes, the hemorrhage, faith, failure, inheritance, and the pieces that are harder to separate from the lives of other people. I want to begin by giving you a manageable foundation rather than asking you to process the entire archive at once.

The pieces are arranged to move from the public thesis, through personal and literary roots, into the current economic and civic arguments. They are not meant to represent a finished book. They are a record of what is already here.

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1. Manifesting an Economic Engine for Shared Prosperity

TEDx West Valley College | March 1, 2025

I included this as the clearest public statement of the work I am doing now. It gives you the central language of shared prosperity, generational inheritance, teaching, ownership, and the question of whether we love other people's children.

2. Reflections on Exiles in My Endless NY

Blog | November 2010

I included this to show the personal and cultural roots of the book: New York, Puerto Rican inheritance, California, movement, exile, belonging, and the complexity of identity. It shows that the questions of return and inheritance have been present in my writing for a long time.

3. On Reading Hopscotch

Early writing | 1992

I included this because it gives you an early example of my literary voice, long before the current economic and civic work. It also reveals the older concerns that still run through the book: exile, dislocation, self-observation, nonlinear form, and the search for meaning through other people's stories.

4. From Scarcity to Solidarity: How Small Players Can Win by Pooling Resources

Newsletter | April 23, 2025

I included this to show how I translate values into practical economic examples. It connects mutual aid, family migration, trust, informal capital, and small-business practice to the larger idea of shared prosperity.

5. Manifesting Shared Prosperity for Economic Democracy

Substack | September 25, 2025

I included this because it is the clearest current version of the structural argument beneath the book's public work. It lays out the connection among ownership, work, capital, technology, predistribution, and democracy.

6. The Importance of Civic Education in 21st-Century America

Substack | May 14, 2026

I included this to show where the work is moving now: public education, civic disagreement, shared reality, participation, and the need to teach people how to engage across difference. It may also help us identify the connection between my public work and the deeper book project.

Manifesting an Economic Engine for Shared Prosperity

TEDx West Valley College | March 1, 2025

The question isn't:

Do you love your children?

The real question is:

Do you love other people's children?

It's easy to protect what we create.

To want to preserve our legacy.

The truth is-we love our children.

And we love other people's children less.

And that distinction is tearing us apart.

We live in the wealthiest country in the world.

I drove around Saratoga this morning. I see how rich you are.

This is the economic engine of the world.

And yet-one out of four children in America is sad, anxious, or depressed.

We are rich.

We have it all.

And yet... we're not happy.

Does that make sense?

We are rich-and yet we are not well.

That's the problem.

It comes from a mindset that more is never enough.

More for you means less for me.

We think:

If that kid gets the scholarship, there's one less for mine.

If that woman gets the job, there's one less opportunity for me.

We have a scarcity mindset...

In a nation of abundance.

We have so much-

Yet when we see someone else succeed, it hurts.

Because we're comparing.

And we don't feel like we deserve it.

It's time to redefine prosperity.

There is no such thing as wealth without wellness.

Generational wealth is generational health.

You cannot have one without the other.

Wealth and health must be in balance.

That's our work.

And the only way to do it...

Is to manifest shared prosperity.

We don't need to imagine something new.

We just need to remember where we came from.

This beautiful woman here is my grandmother, Lydia Rosa Mathew.

She came into New York Harbor in 1927 from San Juan, Puerto Rico.

She had eight kids.

Raised them in the South Bronx and Spanish Harlem during the Great Depression.

She knew about poverty.

She knew about challenges.

But you never heard her complain.

Not a day in her life.

And she loved this country.

My grandfather was a communist.

He got beat up by the cops.

But my grandmother never complained about this country.

Because it gave her opportunity.

She experienced what it's like to go from poverty to prosperity-

in one generation.

And in our family, if one person made it, we all made it.

That's the way it was done.

That was America.

That's the dream I grew up with.

And I see it slipping away.

I've spent the last 25 years connecting:

- Classrooms to the real world
- Students to opportunity
- Communities to prosperity

I was a teacher in the South Bronx,

A teacher in Pasadena,

A teacher in East Oakland.

I loved teaching.

But when I saw it wasn't moving the needle,

I moved into entrepreneurial ecosystem building.

We started connecting high school students to Silicon Valley companies.

Thousands of students-to PayPal, Salesforce, SAP, EY.

But those companies weren't hiring locally.

And our young people-who dreamed of entrepreneurship-
couldn't get access to capital.

So we went back to the roots: small businesses.

That's when my co-founders, Ben Wanzo and Martha Hernandez, and I created ESO Ventures.

A support organization that makes entrepreneurship
accessible and worthwhile in every community.

We wrote legislation.

We started work right here at this community college.

We've incubated over 500 business owners.

We've deployed capital-real capital-into real businesses.

But it's still not enough.

Now I'm working on cooperative business models-
New structures so that small businesses can compete with monopolies.

Because here's what we need:
More on-ramps, not more off-ramps.

We're really good at building exits.
We need to build entrances.
And those entrances must be self-sustaining.

You can't build this with philanthropy.
You need an economic engine.
We need an economic engine for shared prosperity.

It all starts with business.
With risk-taking.
With the entrepreneurial spirit.

You have to put your own sweat equity in.
You have to jump first.
And most folks don't make it to the other side.

But those who do?
That's when the money comes in.
That's when the investors arrive.
That's when everyone gets rich.

Because they jumped first.
They took all the risk.
And they took all the reward.

But if we're going to build an economic engine for shared prosperity,
then once you hit the top of the cycle-that's when the sharing happens.

We cannot build companies where only a small group of people get the benefits.
We need to build a circular economy.
One that is regenerative.
One that grows over time.

So here's the big idea I came to share:

Let's create the first Sovereign Wealth Fund
in the United States of America.

A sovereign wealth fund is:

- A national savings account
- An endowment
- A hedge fund for the people

It's not new.

- Norway has one.
- Saudi Arabia has one.
- Kuwait has one.
- Even Alaska has one.

They take their natural abundance and invest it for the long term,
because one day that abundance will run out.

China has three.

The United States?

We have \$36 trillion in debt.

That's what we're leaving our children.

So how does it work?

We seed the fund with \$1 trillion in assets.

Where does that money come from?

We have land.

We have real estate.

We have the U.S. Treasury.

We can create a token worth \$1 trillion.

We make \$27 trillion a year.

We have \$100 trillion in wealth.

Don't tell me we can't create a \$1 trillion fund.

But don't keep it at the federal level.

This must go into communities.

A network of local endowments across every underinvested community in this country.

Let people democratically steward their own resources.

Three design principles:

1. Last Mile Capital Access

We don't have a capital access problem.

We have a last mile problem.

This fund must get into the soil-into the communities that never get the rain.

It must bridge the gap between local government and private markets.

2. It Must Be Regenerative

This isn't a check you spend.

It's a check you invest.

It compounds.

It grows.

It creates long-term resiliency.

3. You Must Show and Prove

This is not a blank check.

This is a chance to demonstrate impact.

Your community must come together, define its priorities, and track the outcomes.

Financial outcomes.

Social outcomes.

Balanced together.

Now, close your eyes for a moment.

Imagine the community you came from.

Or the one you live in now.

Or the one right next door-

The one forgotten. The one left behind.

Now imagine that community had a well.

A collective resource.

One that grew over time.

Now open your eyes.

What if the world we want to create is a world where we love all children?

Where we share prosperity?

That is the America we can build-together.

Thank you.

Reflections on Exiles in My Endless NY

Blog | November 2010

"We are experiencing the decline of the American age. But how does national or imperial decay influence the lifecycle of a world city?" My Endless New York, By Tony Judt, New York Times Nov. 7th, 2010

Imperial decay as seen through the eyes of the cultural elite, whether it be New York, Paris or London has never been my thing. I love New York, am fascinated by its streets, the faces on the subway, the determination to get where you need to go. Since moving to California, I am removed from its beehive activity, and watch from a place removed. I am of it, always returning to it, but not in it. A world city is a city of exiles, and the true exile experience is not the fashionable streets of Soho, its not an art or a theatre scene, though nothing stimulates creativity like dislocation. The exile is lost, neither here nor there, not American and no longer Ghanaian, or Colombian, or Korean. Not from the South or North alone, but a piece of all places, at home in some, a stranger to others.

As an Anglo Rican, a mestizo Puerto Rican, who's grandparents arrived in NY in 1927 from a small island conquered by the U.S. after being conquered by Spain, a banana republic in a beautiful sea. NY to me is the African and the Taino, mixed with the Italian, the Irish, the German, and Jew. It is my family born in Spanish Harlem, moved to Union Ave and 161st, and the success of constant movement, from the Bronx to Westchester to wherever the heart and mind and hands can take you. It is the marriage of my father to my mother, the city cat and the country mouse, and the strength it takes to raise a family in this crazy world. It is as the Ric Burns documentary embues so well, a city for reinventing yourself.

I'm less concerned with the tassels and bows of world class city status, the cultural chic who jet set for shopping and parties, or even the intellectuals who once used to crowd City College or take center stage like Baldwin and Mailer. The cultural or intellectual center of an age, the New York centric focus of an early day, is pretty to read about in books but it denies too much lived experience. Our problem is the narrow focus of our humanity, our unwillingness to embrace the complexity of the exile.

I have a problem with Europeans in New York. They love the un-Americaness of the city. They love to shop and buy Manhattan apartments. They feed off of the world culture produced by its inhabitants while only skimming the surface of reality, never having to fear the loss of self. One of the problems with being rich, is you never have to belong to the places you go. You travel without adapting, without embracing, without ever getting lost.

I love the exile, and people who can express it. When I was younger I loved George Orwell's essays, and his "tourism among the dogs". I also loved V.S. Naipul's novels and the cross roads he describes in the West Indies and East Africa. But no one disrobes them quite like Edward W. Said, the Palestinian literary critic when he writes about Orwell:

"In Down and Out he makes a revealing admission about the nature of the worry that plagued him. Once you hit absolute bottom, he says, there comes a sense that "you have talked so often of going to the dogs- and well, here are the dogs, and you have reached them, and you can stand it. It takes off a lot of anxiety." Not standing it- "it" being the psycho-moral strain of falling apart completely, losing your identity as defined for you by where you come from and where most of the time you know you can return. Surely the removal of this last option causes the peculiar dread experienced by Winston Smith during his final ordeal in 1984, the more so after having lost the cosy sanctuary he shared with Julia above Mr. Carrington's shop. Just as surely, the off-stage presence of home and the possibility of a

phone call for money to Eric Blair's (aka G. Orwell) Aunt Nellie constitute the narrator's bad faith when he was a plongeur in Paris or a tramp in England." Reflections on Exile, by Edward W. Said "Toursims Among the Dogs" p. 95

Like Thoreau getting a weekly pie from his mother during his solitude at Walden Pond or having his taxes paid by friends after one night of prison, Orwell is too addicted to comfort to know what it is to hit bottom. We live in an age where the prestige of eradicating poverty is moving mountains, but institutions like UC Berkeley ignore East Oakland, 96th Street on the East side still divides the rich from the projects of Harlem, and the privileged are voyeurs but not participants in a faceless world.

On Reading Hopscotch

Early writing | 1992

He's one of those Latin American Boom writers from the '60s. Supposedly-if I've got it right-this novel was quite important to the development of modern literature in the South.

Cortázar scrambled the novel, breaking it into 155 sections, which must be weaved through. At the end of each chapter, there's a note telling the reader where to go next. The sections seldom connect the storyline directly-forcing mental leaps. It's confusing, but worthwhile. It makes a game of reading, as the title suggests.

At one point, he even runs two dialogues on the same page. This guy, Oliveira, is reading some trashy Spanish novel on the odd lines, and his thoughts about his lover, La Maga, appear on the even.

It's modern shit, all right.

Funny that Joyce took almost 40 years to travel southwest.

Much of the book revolves around the disruption of form. Reinventing language. Disassociation. Attacking literature and Cartesian thought. Basically, it's an upheaval-full of tangents and wandering eyes. The main character is a metaphysical type from Buenos Aires, on a self-imposed exile in Paris. A strange man with insights that seem to lead nowhere. An observer of himself and things.

He has a love affair with La Maga and others, but he seems to drop them all.

I'm really enjoying the story. I don't know where Oliveira will go or what will come of his search, but just envisioning a mismatch of international intellectuals in the late '50s, getting drunk on Cointreau at dawn, listening to American jazz in some Parisian flat, discussing absurdity and whose reality is whose-eating, drinking, fucking, not working, but meeting people on the streets, putting each other down, hurting and misunderstanding each other-touches my historical arteries.

Though it is a novel, the dialogues and interactions all seem plausible-like Cortázar is transcribing the life of his mind with this crew in that foreign city.

I believe it all.

The '50s were a great time for a lifestyle built on honestly penetrating the nature of things. Becoming a manic-depressive hipster.

Forty years later, the portal to that quest seems to have been incorporated, co-opted, merged with the rubbernecking commuter class. Clogged with hardware, magazines, videos, films, and other general information. Just a bunch of people and shit so utterly imposing they're probably not even real.

The book makes it difficult to feel pity for people. There's a harsh, drawn rawness about it.

So the characters are interchangeably ugly and weak-or transcendingly beautiful-depending on the momentary angle.

No one has pity for one another. They usually ignore each other's pain, always too concerned with the enigma of their own troubles.

But every once in a while—once in a time—a hand is reached out, someone's hair gets stroked, or a man and woman sodder themselves together in an embrace.

Even if it's just the calling of a name—someone's illusion is bolstered. And they're happy.

Those moments drive the novel.

Because in between, it's all emptiness—figments of thought and mismanaged action.

Cortázar has a fine sense of style. No sentimentality. No plot.

Yet he manages to create sensitive individuals with just the right mix of complexity that they don't explode.

It's a masculine thing. It's solitary.

But Cortázar has something of the gleam. He respects authors. James Baldwin's writing also rubs mud in my wounds. Maybe they only had one long, frayed rope—but their internal destruction is something to watch.

They seem to have chosen to reject themselves and the world in some fundamental way. To clear the slate, and then begin the building process.

I'm thankful for their efforts. Maybe they wrote out of need.

But they offered themselves up in the process—letting young boys and girls like us get in on the work and improvise our own structures, our own buildings and identities.

I guess that's why I read. Maybe why you do too.

To get those kernels out of the past—to get outside ourselves by going inside.

Falling apart by entropy is effortless. Returning to a concentrated whole is an actualizing process.

The leaf flutters down, breaking itself, branch by branch, lost in the brown mattress.

From Scarcity to Solidarity: How Small Players Can Win by Pooling Resources

Newsletter | April 23, 2025

What does it actually mean to pool resources and embrace capitalism for shared prosperity?

What does that look like in the real world? Where is it being done? Where has it been done before?

At its most basic level, pooling resources is mutual aid. Your neighbor needs a cup of sugar and doesn't want to go to the store. Can they borrow some? Of course. In small ways and large, we show up for each other. When someone we love is in crisis-a car accident, a brain aneurysm, the death of a child-we don't think twice. We move. We help. We hold. Grief brings out our shared humanity. Our decency. Crisis creates connection.

But that's not what you're asking.

You're asking: how does this work economically? Among strangers? Among organizations raised on competition, on performance, on scarcity and meritocracy? How do we build mutual aid into our business practices, our operations, our systems?

Let me offer a few tangible examples-and then a framework for how we begin designing around these principles.

1. Informal Capital Networks (Samaj, Tandas, and Giving Circles)

When my wife's family immigrated to the U.S. from Gujarat, they opened a motel near Disneyland in the late 1970s. The capital came not from a bank, but from their Samaj-an extended family and community network that pooled resources to help newcomers get established.

You make the investment. You pay it back when you can. No interest. No collateral. No contracts. Just trust.

This model-like Tandas in Mexico or small giving circles in many cultures around the world-operates outside the financial system. It isn't growth-oriented, but it gets the job done. It works because of deep cultural ties and long-standing relationships-something our impersonal financial system can rarely replicate. Many trust based CDFIs in the US model their character based lending on this type of relationship for business owners without the credit, collateral and cash flow to access traditional markets.

2. Cash Flow Pooling

Cash flow is one of the most persistent challenges for small businesses and nonprofits. A practical solution? A group of aligned enterprises can create a shared cash management system.

Imagine a joint bank account, or a pooled cash waterfall structure, where organizations support each other's liquidity. One month, I will keep you afloat. Next month, you cover me. No need for 28% interest QuickBooks lines of credit. This is informal negotiating of mutually beneficial terms, based on trust and reciprocity, not predatory finance.

3. Bulk Purchasing & Shared Services

Small businesses pay more per unit because they can't buy at scale. But if we buy together, we can negotiate better terms with wholesalers and distributors. It works in agriculture. It works in housing. It works in every sector where fragmentation drives up costs.

Shared Services Cooperatives are a proven model. Nathan Schneider (University of Colorado Boulder) and Greg Brodsky (Start.coop) have both been evangelists in this space. Greg shared the story of his father, Howard Brodsky, who helped create one of the nation's largest shared services cooperatives in the flooring industry.

In the 1960s, small carpet retailers were getting crushed by big box chains. Insurers only reimbursed products from national suppliers. Howard negotiated for local stores to be included-but only if there was a storefront in every market. That meant scaling a federated network. Independent stores stayed independently owned, but they shared purchasing power, branding, contracts, and a national logistics backbone.

The model worked. It still does.

4. Private Equity Rollups as a Blueprint

Private equity has figured this out. They target fragmented, recession-proof sectors (HVAC, auto repair, car washes), acquire mom-and-pops, merge them under one brand, and centralize operations. The goal: scale efficiencies and financial arbitrage. Buy at 2x earnings. Sell at 10x. Wash. Rinse. Repeat.

We need to reclaim and repurpose this private equity strategy for public interest. Not to extract and exit, but to cooperate and stay.

5. Tech Empires Do It Too

Look at what Elon Musk is doing. Tesla, SpaceX, X (formerly Twitter), xAI-he's pooling resources across divisions, sharing data, talent, infrastructure, and media firepower. Apple and Google do it. Berkshire Hathaway is built on this.

But these platforms are closed. Gatekept. Extractive. We need to build open platforms. Shared infrastructure. Commons-based protocols that help smaller players aggregate value without losing control and power.

Applying these models in the Civic Sector

Most small nonprofits, universities, and civic institutions have been trained to compete. For grants. For students. For clients. For survival.

But what if they didn't?

What if they pooled their budgets for procurement? Shared their marketing backends? Developed common metrics for impact? What if they negotiated as a block with funders, insurers, and vendors?

These are not radical ideas. They are common sense adaptations to the complexity of our time.

My friend and colleague, Paulo Gregory, has designed a game called Cohado, that exemplifies this zeitgeist. His tagline, maximize assets and minimize waste, is a rallying cry we should all be embracing. For years he's been leading workshops, training communities on these principles, and he's not alone. Many people are searching for a way out from a rat race we know we will never win.

We've been taught to hoard. To protect. To isolate. To keep our social, financial, intellectual capital separate.

And so we suffer-alone.

I just don't believe we were meant to do anything alone.

If you're in the 1% of companies chasing VC, go for it. Compete. Win. Scale. Exit.

But if you're a school, a hospital, a nonprofit, a youth development org, a locally owned business in a fragmented market-

Cooperate. Share services. Pool risk. Build with others.

That's how we create resilient, cost-effective, and thriving local economies.

I'm on a mission to keep learning, and to put these principles into action. If you have something to teach me, I'm listening. If you want to learn, I'll share what I know.

And if you need some sugar for your recipe-please, ask a neighbor.

We need one another more than we know.

Manifesting Shared Prosperity for Economic Democracy

Substack | September 25, 2025

At the core of the American Dream lies the belief in selfdetermination. For generations, this promise was simple: work hard, play by the rules, go to school, and a job would lead to homeownership, stability, and opportunity for your children.

That pathway is now broken. Wages have stagnated while the real costs of survival from housing, healthcare, education, energy, to groceries continue to climb. Millions of families live paycheck to paycheck, renters paying someone else's mortgage instead of building equity. Prosperity today is determined less by labor than by capital. Without ownership of appreciating assets-real estate, equity stakes, or businesses-most Americans cannot maintain stability, let alone build generational wealth.

Without ownership of appreciating assets-real estate, equity stakes, or businesses-most Americans cannot maintain stability, let alone build generational wealth.

Economist Thomas Piketty captured the imbalance in a simple formula: $r > g$. The rate of return on capital consistently outpaces economic growth and wage increases. This structural bias means that wealth naturally concentrates in the hands of asset owners, while wage earners fall further behind.

Technology is magnifying the divide. Artificial intelligence is not creating a new paradigm, it is intensifying the one we already have. AI automates both physical and cognitive tasks, driving wealth to those who own the platforms, infrastructure, and data. The gains accrue to capital holders, not to the workers who train, sustain, and depend on these systems.

This is not only an economic failure; it is a democratic one. Ownership has always conferred agency. Universal suffrage in law is hollow if the majority is excluded from meaningful participation in wealth creation. Without a personal stake in the economy, civic voice is detached from real power. Democracy is only possible when citizens have the financial independence to participate. As John Jay observed, "Those who own the country ought to govern it." Political freedom is limited without economic freedom.

For nearly a century, redistribution through safety nets helped stabilize a society built on a high degree of economic inequality. Programs like Social Security, Medicare, and subsidies caught families when markets failed to meet basic needs. But redistribution is reaching its limits. The Social Security Trust Fund is projected to be partially insolvent within a decade. Healthcare, housing, and education costs continue to outpace wages, forcing families into deeper reliance on public programs already overstretched. Redistribution treats symptoms; it does not fix causes.

We need a new approach: predistribution. Instead of waiting to fix inequality after the fact, we embed ownership into the system from the beginning.

We need a new approach: predistribution. Instead of waiting to fix inequality after the fact, we embed work-to-owner pathways into the system from the beginning. Instead of paying rent, tuition, or medical bills into someone else's pocket, families would build equity with every payment. Costs become assets. Burdens become engines of wealth.

This is the vision behind the Shared Prosperity Model. It is not a manifesto. It is a structural redesign of capitalism itself, combining the discipline of markets with the broad distribution of ownership needed to sustain democracy.

The Shared Prosperity Model integrates proven tools from private equity roll-ups, Employee Stock Ownership Plans (ESOPs), cooperative shared service structures, and Louis Kelso's idea of "universal capitalism." On their own, each tool has limits. Together, they coalesce into a new system built with these underlying principles.

Predistribution instead of redistribution. Ownership from the start, not after inequality calcifies.

Aggregation without extraction. Fragmented small businesses rolled into community corporations that keep wealth local. Capital that pays for itself. Future savings and enterprise profits repay upfront investments, without burdening workers with debt. Flywheel logic. Every acquisition and liquidity event strengthens the system, compounding wealth and expanding ownership.

This model proposes a new generation of worker-owned community corporations that can contract with hospitals, retrofit homes for energy efficiency, or manage real estate in disinvested corridors so that community residents benefit from revitalization. Each community corporation becomes part of a federated network that grows stronger with every turn of the flywheel.

The stakes are clear. If ownership remains concentrated, inequality will deepen, democracy will erode, and economic populism will feed instability. But if we embed ownership, broaden access to capital, and align markets with community well-being, we can flip the script.

This Substack will help us workshop this vision. Here we will share frameworks, field notes, and stories of pilots in motion. We're not asking for passive endorsement. We're inviting co-builders: entrepreneurs, funders, policymakers, and readers who believe the American Dream must be redefined for the 21st century.

The invitation is simple: help us prove that work can once again generate wealth, that communities can own the engines of their survival, and that democracy can be renewed through dignity, agency, and hope. Welcome to Shared Prosperity.

POLL What concept are you interested in learning more about?

Predistribution

CSOPs & Community Corporations

Worker-to-Owner Pathways

The Importance of Civic Education in 21st-Century America

Substack | May 14, 2026

Civic education matters today not because Americans lack opinions, but because we lack shared practices for engaging across our differences.

The United States enters the 21st century as a large, powerful, and deeply interconnected society. Our economic system, military reach, technological platforms, and policy decisions shape life at home and abroad. As citizens and taxpayers in a republic, Americans are implicated in these outcomes whether we feel close to power or not. Participation is not optional. But meaningful participation requires preparation.

For much of the last century, schools treated civic education as either basic instruction in how the government works or as a means of fostering a shared national identity. In recent decades, civic education has become increasingly entangled in our broader political polarization. Competing pressures from parents and school boards, heightened scrutiny over what gets taught, and contested history classrooms have led many districts to narrow the curriculum or avoid open dialogue altogether. The result has been a generation of students less engaged, less informed, and less prepared to grapple with real civic disagreement.

We need a different approach.

What civic education should not try to do

Civic education should not attempt to settle arguments about whether the United States is fundamentally good or bad, or which voices belong in a fixed canon. It should not aim to persuade students toward a particular ideology. Instead, it should start from a simpler and more demanding premise.

The United States is the most powerful nation in the world. It has been for decades. Its system will continue to shape outcomes regardless of whether people feel represented by it.

Critique is necessary. But critique alone does not change systems. Shaping outcomes requires working within a shared political and economic reality, even when there is deep disagreement about the past and competing visions for the future. The question is not whether to engage. The question is how to engage well.

Three positions, all present at once

In a society as large and diverse as the United States, three positions on our economic and political system exist simultaneously. A serious civic education makes room for all three.

No single one of these groups gets to decide the direction of a society this large.

Economic democracy, in practice, is not about constant agreement or universal participation. It is about understanding how decisions are made amid conflict, constraint, and competing values, and how those decisions can be influenced responsibly over time.

The central civic skill

The most important civic skill today is not memorization. It is not argumentation in isolation. It is the ability to engage seriously with opposing views, to understand why reasonable people disagree, and to weigh tradeoffs without retreating into cynicism or certainty.

This is a much harder skill than the one our schools have been teaching. It asks students to do six things, none of them easy:

None of these are skills you pick up by accident. They have to be practiced. They have to be modeled. They have to be taught in environments where disagreement is not punished and where students are not graded on whether they arrive at the right answer, but on whether they engage the question seriously.

This is the deepest difference between civic education as it is and civic education as it needs to be. The version we have been running treats disagreement as a problem to be managed. The version we need treats disagreement as the substance of democratic life.

Reform as a democratic skill American history shows that reform, rather than revolution, has been a primary source of stability and prosperity in this country. That is not a conservative claim about preserving the status quo. It is a structural observation about how durable change happens in democratic systems.

These moments were deeply contested. They were incomplete. They were often unjust in their execution. But each one reflects a recurring American choice to build on what exists rather than start from zero. A serious civic education treats that choice - reform over rupture - not as cowardice, but as a democratic skill worth teaching.

This matters now because we are entering another one of those moments. The questions we are about to face as a country - about debt, about ownership, about the role of AI in our economy, about who participates in the wealth this country produces - are reform questions in the American tradition. They will be answered. The only question is who participates in answering them, and whether those who participate are prepared.

Why this matters now

In a society facing economic transition, demographic change, and technological disruption, the ability to participate thoughtfully remains one of the most important civic capacities we can cultivate. As more decisions are shaped by systems, incentives, and algorithms, the role of human judgment does not disappear. It becomes more important.

The future will require people who can weigh values, understand consequences, and take responsibility, rather than deferring agency to automated processes or distant authorities. That is hard work. It is the work civic education exists to support.

Civic education is not a specialized subject reserved for future politicians or policy experts. It is foundational for all of us.

Disagreement is not a failure of democracy. It is a condition of it.

Responsibility lies not in having the right view, but in engaging the system in ways that move toward productive solutions.

We have done very little, over the past several decades, to prepare ourselves or our children for the choices this country is about to make. There is no version of the next ten years in which we get to avoid those choices. The work of cultivating the civic capacity to make them, together, is the work in front of us.

That work begins with a different kind of classroom. It also begins with a different kind of conversation in our homes, our workplaces, our houses of worship, and our public spaces.

We do not need to agree. We need to be willing to disagree well.